

RECORD DEAL IN AUTHORS' AI SUIT

Anthropic agrees to pay \$1.5 billion to copyright holders in landmark agreement.

By QUEENIE WONG

Chatbot builder Anthropic agreed to pay \$1.5 billion to authors in a landmark copyright settlement that could redefine how artificial intelligence companies compensate creators.

The San Francisco-based startup is ready to pay authors and publishers to settle a lawsuit that accused the company of illegally using their work to train its chatbot.

Anthropic developed an AI assistant named Claude that can generate text, images, code and more. Writers, artists and other creative professionals have raised concerns that Anthropic and other tech companies are using their work to train their AI systems without their permission and not fairly compensating them.

As part of the settlement, which the judge still needs to approve, Anthropic agreed to pay authors \$3,000 per work for an estimated 500,000 books. It's the largest settlement known for a copyright case, signaling to other tech companies facing copyright infringement allegations that they might have to pay rights holders eventually as well.

Meta and OpenAI, the maker of ChatGPT, have also been sued over alleged copyright infringement. Walt Disney Co. and Universal Pictures have sued AI company Midjourney, which the studios allege trained its image generation models on their copyrighted materials.

"It will provide meaningful compensation for each class work and sets a precedent requiring AI companies to pay copyright owners," Justin Nelson, a lawyer for the authors, said in a statement. "This settlement sends a powerful message to AI companies and creators alike that taking copyrighted works from these pirate websites is wrong."

Last year, authors Andrea Bartz, Charles Graeber and Kirk Wallace Johnson sued Anthropic, alleging that the company committed "large-scale theft" and trained its chatbot on pirated copies of copyrighted books.

U.S. District Judge William Alsup of San Francisco ruled in June that Anthropic's use of the books to train the AI models constituted "fair use," so it wasn't illegal. But the judge also ruled that the startup had improperly downloaded millions of books through online libraries.

Fair use is a legal doctrine in U.S. copyright law that allows for the limited use of copyrighted materials without permission in certain cases, such as teaching, criticism and news reporting. AI companies have pointed to that doctrine as a defense when sued over alleged copyright violations.

Anthropic, founded by former OpenAI employees and backed by Amazon, pirated at least 7 million books [See [Anthropic](#), A14]



Photographs by MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

BURNBOT, above, creates a controlled burn, top, to incinerate flammable vegetation and help reduce fire risk. The giant vehicle is operated by remote control.

A robot tames the flames

BurnBot, called a 'Roomba for the forest,' could be the Southland's next wildfire weapon

By Noah Haggerty

The giant, remote-controlled vehicle — somewhere between a tractor trailer, a tank and a Zamboni in appearance — slowly rolled across the dry, brittle grass growing between the tangle of freeways making up the 101 and 23 interchange in Thousand Oaks.

Inside the beast, fire churned. And as it rolled over the land, that fire incinerated any brush it encountered, leaving only a thin smoke cloud billowing from the top of the machine, some flashes of orange and red from behind its metal skirt and, in its wake, a desolate, smoldering black line.

BurnBot isn't the fastest way to rid a landscape of

dangerously flammable vegetation (it tops out at around 0.5 mph) but it can do something that traditional vegetation management techniques cannot: With almost surgical precision, it can kill the flammable brush sitting within feet of homes and highways on even the hottest and driest days and with virtually no safety risks or disruptions to daily life.

On a recent summer afternoon, as wildland firefighters maneuvered the machine and mopped up the charred earth on a stretch of highway about 30 miles west of Los Angeles on the 101, a who's who of SoCal's wildfire leadership looked on — from

the California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection, local fire departments, Caltrans, the U.S. forest and park services, Southern California Edison and the state Legislature. The sweet smoky smell of wildland fire permeated the hot midday air. The onlookers quietly took notes.

"We have to do everything we can to try to figure out ways to lower our wildfire risk in a psychologically friendly way — we don't want to just turn this beautiful environment into concrete," state Sen. Benjamin Allen (D-Santa Monica) told the crowd while standing atop BurnBot's metal skirt. [See [BurnBot](#), A9]

CBS' 'Face the Nation' will not edit taped interviews

By STEPHEN BATTAGLIO

CBS News' "Face the Nation" will no longer edit taped interviews after Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem complained about how her remarks were cut in her last appearance on the Washington-based program.

The news division said Friday that the Sunday show moderated by Margaret Brennan will present only interviews live or "live to tape" in which no edits are made. Exceptions will be made when classified national security information is inadvertently stated or language is used that violates Federal Communications Commission broad-

cast standards.

"In response to audience feedback over the past week, we have implemented a new policy for greater transparency in our interviews," a CBS News representative said in a statement. "This extra measure means the television audience will see the full, unedited interview on CBS and we will continue our practice of posting full transcripts and the unedited video online."

The representative declined to comment on the reason for the policy change beyond the statement.

But the timing makes it clear that CBS News is reacting to Noem's complaints after her Sunday appearance in which she discussed the case of Kilmar Abrego

Garcia, the Maryland man wrongly deported to his native El Salvador. He was returned to the U.S., where he faces deportation efforts.

The complaints from Noem and the White House led George Cheeks, president and chief executive of CBS, and CBS News President Tom Cibrowski to come up with the new policy, according to a person familiar with the discussions who was not authorized to comment.

Noem wrote on X that "CBS shamefully edited the interview to whitewash the truth about this MS-13 gang member and the threat he poses to American public safety."

The Trump administration [See [Editing](#), A14]

U.S. job growth declines amid erratic economy

Companies become more reluctant to hire with Trump's policies breeding uncertainty.

By PAUL WISEMAN, ANNE D'INNOCENZIO AND CORA LEWIS

The American job market, a pillar of U.S. economic strength since the pandemic, is crumbling under the weight of President Trump's erratic economic policies.

Uncertain about where things are headed, companies have grown increasingly reluctant to hire, leaving agonized job seekers unable to find work and weighing on consumers who account for 70% of all U.S. economic activity. Their spending has been the engine behind the world's biggest economy since the COVID-19 disruptions of 2020.

The Labor Department reported Friday that U.S. employers — companies, government agencies and nonprofits — added just 22,000 jobs last month, down from 79,000 in July and well

below the 80,000 that economists had expected.

The unemployment rate ticked up to 4.3% last month, also worse than expected and the highest since 2021.

"U.S. labor market deterioration intensified in August," Scott Anderson, chief U.S. economist at BMO Capital Market, wrote in a commentary, noting that hiring was "slumping dangerously close to stall speed. This raises the risk of a harder landing for consumer spending and the economy in the months ahead."

Alexa Mamoulides, 27, was laid off in the spring from a job at a research publishing company and has been hunting for work ever since. She uses a spreadsheet to track her progress and said she's applied for 111 positions and had 14 interviews — but hasn't landed a job yet.

"There have been a lot of ups and downs," Mamoulides said. "At the beginning I wasn't too stressed, but now that September is here, I've been wondering how much longer it will take. It's validating that the numbers bear out my experience, but [See [Jobs](#), A12]

LAPD chief grilled over marked rise in police shootings

By LIBOR JANY

After Los Angeles police officers shot at people on three consecutive days late last month, the LAPD's civilian bosses turned to Chief Jim McDonnell for an explanation.

The Police Commission wanted to know: What more could the department be doing to keep officers from opening fire?

But in his response at the panel's meeting last week, McDonnell seemed to bristle at the notion his officers were too trigger-happy.

"I think what we're seeing is an uptick in the willingness of criminals within the community to assault officers head-on," he said at the Aug. 26 meeting. "And then officers respond with what they have to do in order to control it."

The commission has heaped praise on McDonnell for his performance since

taking over the department in November. But the exchange over the recent cluster of police shootings — part of an overall increase that has seen officers open fire in 31 incidents this year, up from 20 at the same point in 2024 — marked a rare point of contention.

Commission Vice President Rasha Gerdes Shields told the chief that she and her colleagues remained "troubled by the dealings of people both with edged weapons — knives, other things like that — and also those who are in the midst of a mental health crisis."

During a radio appearance earlier this year, the chief brushed aside questions about shootings, saying officers are often put into dangerous situations where they have no choice but to open fire in order to protect themselves or the public.

"That is something that's part of the job, unfortunately [See [Shootings](#), A7]



ETIENNE LAURENT For The Times

READY TO ROCK

Oasis mania has come to the Southland. Fans are hyped for Rose Bowl shows. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

War Department name is revived

Trump's executive order aims to rebrand the Department of Defense, which he said was "woke." **NATION, A7**

Weather

Clouds, then sun. L.A. Basin: 87/65. **B8**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Musk in line for \$1-trillion payout

Tesla asking investors to approve proposed compensation based on goals. **BUSINESS, A11**

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Clippers considered naming arena after firm

By STEVE HENSON

More details are emerging about a company that allegedly paid Clippers star Kawhi Leonard millions, including that the team came close in 2021 to granting naming rights for its Inglewood arena to Aspiration Partners.

Clippers owner Steve Ballmer nearly granted naming rights to the company, but ended up choosing

financial services firm Intuit to grace the \$2-billion venue, a source familiar with the matter said. Intuit, which has a \$186-billion net worth and developed TurboTax, Credit Karma and QuickBooks, ended up paying a reported \$500 million over 23 years for the naming rights. The source requested anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly.

Four years later, Aspiration, a sustainability firm

that also generated and sold carbon credits, is out of business. Co-founder Joseph Sanberg has agreed to plead guilty to defrauding multiple investors and lenders. Listed among creditors in Aspiration's bankruptcy documents is Leonard, raising questions about whether his \$28-million endorsement deal with the company skirted NBA salary cap rules.

One of the investors Sanberg defrauded was Ballmer,

listed by Fortune magazine as the sixth-richest person in the world, with a net worth of \$157 billion. The Clippers owner invested \$50 million in Aspiration, which in turn entered into a \$330-million sponsorship agreement with the team.

This week, the Athletic reported allegations that Aspiration agreed to pay Leonard \$28 million for a job with no responsibilities. Anonymous sources quoted [See [Clippers](#), A9]